We came back feeling great. As good a time as I'd had, I couldn't wait to see Victoria and Brooklyn. I couldn't wait to get back to some mud, wind and rain either, to get on with the rest of the season. While we'd been away, no other team had been able to catch up on our lead: the Premiership was there to be won. And we were still in the Champions League. The first game back was against Arsenal at Old Trafford and they almost caught us cold. We ended up drawing 1–1, though, and it was a game they maybe needed to win more than we did. From then on, it felt like we were just picking up where we'd left off. I was so relaxed and enjoying my soccer so much, why would I have stopped to think what might upset the roll we were on? There was a kind of ambush waiting for me, of course, but I'd not have been any better prepared for dealing with it even if I'd somehow seen it coming.

On Saturday 12 February we took a 3–0 hiding at Newcastle. That didn't help the manager's—or anybody else's—mood over the following week, as we built up to another big game that weekend, away to Leeds. As with players at most clubs when there's not a midweek game, we were given some time off: I was down at the house in London, planning to drive back on the Wednesday night for training on Thursday morning. During the day, Brooklyn was really sick. With a first child, maybe there's an extra intensity to your feelings about things because you don't recognize symptoms: everything to do with being a parent is new, after all. Maybe now, with Romeo, I'd not have worried like I did back then. By around seven that Wednesday evening, though, Brooklyn was running a fever and had gone all floppy. I was holding him in my lap and just getting no reaction from him. We didn't know what was going on: any mum or dad will know how scary that is. By the time the doctor told us Brooklyn had gastro-enteritis, I'd already made the decision to stay at home for the night and get driven to Manchester early the following morning.

Brooklyn was so uncomfortable and I hated seeing him like that. When we eventually got him off to sleep—who knows what time of the night it was by then?—I stayed in his room and slept for a few hours on the bed next to his cot. I woke up and got away by six the next morning: the plan was I'd be able to sleep a bit more in the back of the car on the drive north. But I couldn't get my boy out of my mind: how sick he'd been and how wrong it felt to be leaving him and Victoria behind. Victoria had said I should go, that Brooklyn would be fine, but all my instincts were telling me that my place was at home with them, at least until I knew for sure Brooklyn was going to be all right. I needed to see an improvement in him for myself. Twenty minutes up the highway, I asked the driver to turn round. And, to be honest, even if I'd known what the consequences were going to be, I'd still have made that same